2026 D Course: Coaching Training Session

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~20 min drill for u15+ requiring around 12-16 players

This is an attacking drill focused on ball movement transitioning through middle third.

Training Session Objective

- Possession
- Control middle third of field
- Passes with intention
- First (directional) touch under pressure
- AVOID: long ball / 40yrd line breaking passes

Desired Behavior

Main Principle (attacking): Possession while probing for offensive third penetration.

Sub Principles: Passing angles, speed of play, vision

Player Actions:

- Scan prior to and during pass all before the ball arrives. Decision for next pass should be made prior to receivign the ball
- Directed first touch into space or to directed area
- Pass and move / support the next pass
- Play forward when it’s on and recognize then recycle when it’s not

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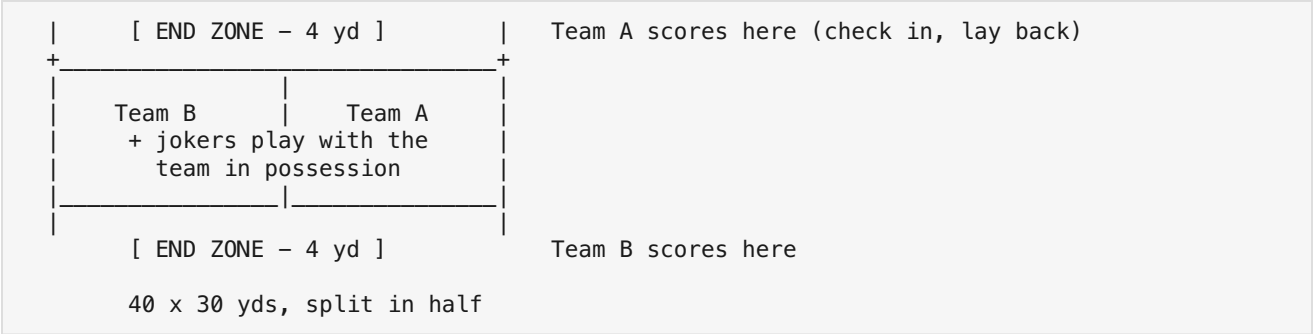
Coaching Points (age-appropriate language)

- Constant assess positioning & seems for opportunities
- Check your shoulder as the ball is being passed
- Have two options. Decision shouod usually be made before ball gets there.
- Open up hips or have them oriented to that first touch
- Intentional first touch. So keep it in control at your feet or direct it into space
- Pass and move
- Watch the weight, not just direction, of your pass
- Be decisive. Fast and wrong often beats slow and perfect in pressure situations

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Activity Objective: Keep the ball and progress it forward through pressure, using a pre-scan and a directional first touch to play into a target player in the end zone.

Setup: 6v6 with 2 neutral jokers who always play for whoever has the ball (8v6 in possession). Two 4-yard target end zones instead of goals.



6v6 (+/- 1 as needed) with 2 jokers middle third of field, can scale up/down as needed given numbers

Scoring - 1 point for completing pass into the end zone under control - 2 points if the pass into the end zone is first time or directional first touch

Duration/Timeline - Best of 5 points or 5 minutes - quick chat over player actions or not based on how it went - cycle out jokers - repeat, 3 times today then get water

Play - coach to play ball in or decide who does (eg own endzone) - out of bounds and restart play for opposite team in endzone (throw ins are another beast and not the focus of this drill) - Add constraints as needed (eg 2 touch only)

Coaching Interactions

Go over the “what” of the activity listed above (scan, open hips, first touch, etc). Provide a demo of anything you really want to see. In this drill, controlled or directional first touches are likely something to demo/talk about.

Probably a good first drill (also aligns with play-practice-play) after warmups.

Afer going over player actions, hang back and watch how they do. Ask what they saw after the first period. Perhaps talk a bit more during second perior. Walking around talking to individuals is a common form of teaching without breaking stride for players.

Not ideal, but every once and a while freeze people. I do it often to introduce OR to drive a point home that has, perhaps, already been talked about sevearl times and it just keeps happening.